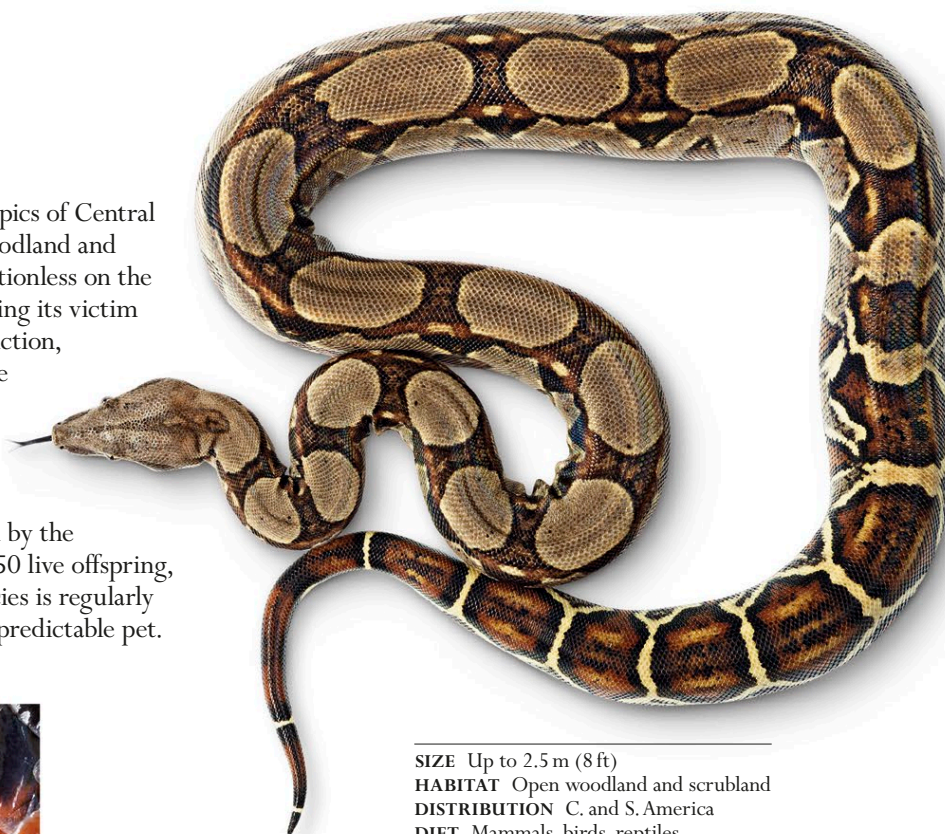


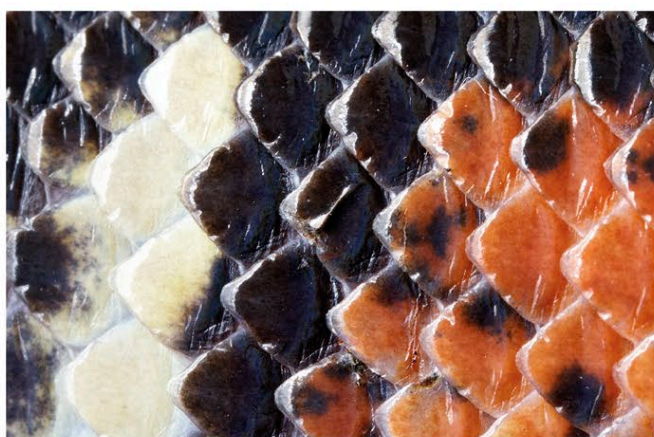
COMMON BOA

Boa constrictor

The common boa is a large terrestrial snake from the tropics of Central and South America. Although they are often found in woodland and scrub, boas easily adapt to a variety of habitats. Lying motionless on the ground, the snake ambushes its mammalian prey – grasping its victim with its jaws, it coils around the body and kills by constriction, tightening its coils with every exhalation of its prey. Once dead, the prey is swallowed head first. The left and right sides of the boa's lower jaw separate in front, and can open wide to take astonishingly large prey. Usually a solitary species, males will actively seek out a partner at breeding times, attracted by the scent emitted by the female. Larger than males, female boas give birth to 30–50 live offspring, each measuring around 30 cm (12 in) in length. This species is regularly seen in captivity but its propensity to bite makes it an unpredictable pet.



SIZE Up to 2.5 m (8 ft)
HABITAT Open woodland and scrubland
DISTRIBUTION C. and S. America
DIET Mammals, birds, reptiles

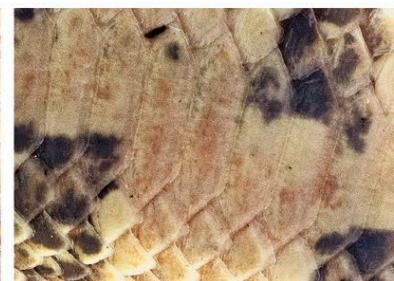


^ COLOUR VARIANTS

There are numerous subspecies of common boa, which are defined on the basis of size and colour patterns. Colour also varies considerably between localities.

> CAMOUFLAGE

Pigmentation of some scales forms patches of colour that disrupt the outline of the snake. This helps with camouflage when hunting prey or evading predators.



^ BELLY SCALES

The robust belly scales grip most surfaces, allowing the common boa to pull itself along and climb trees. It periodically sheds its skin.

> SIZEABLE FOE

The common boa hunts by sight and smell, so the eyes and nostrils are prominent on the triangular head. Feeding can be infrequent – a small prey item may last a snake two to three weeks. A large snake that kills a deer will not need to feed for at least six months.

distinctive,
saddle-like
markings

